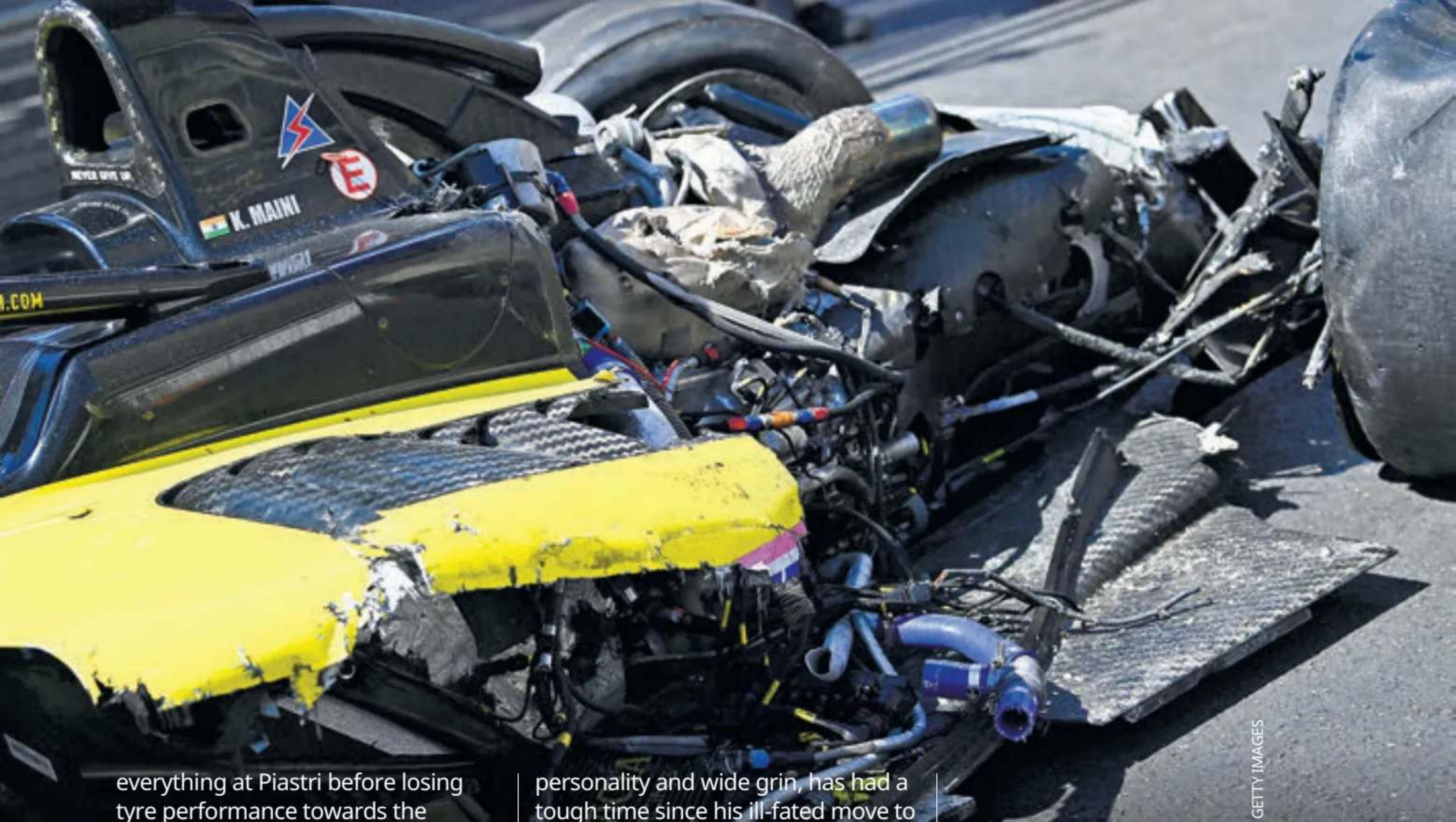




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everything at Piastri before losing tyre performance towards the closing stages. On lap 50, Sergio Perez and Carlos Sainz crashed into each other while trying to catch Leclerc. George Russell was the beneficiary and secured third place.

Eyeing the big prize

Piastri's win in Baku allowed McLaren to take the lead in the constructors' championship for the first time this year. The 1-3 result in Singapore helped the British team extend its lead to 41 points over Red Bull. McLaren, which last won the constructors' title in 1998, is looking to end its 26-year drought. While the drivers' title is the most prestigious, the constructors' standings matter more, as they determine the prize money teams receive and staff bonuses, which are linked to the team's position in the standings. It would take a remarkable turnaround from Red Bull or Ferrari to take the title away from McLaren in the final six races.

Honey Badger's last hurrah?

It's rare for a driver finishing 18th to become the talking point, but after the Singapore GP, there was unease in the paddock with rumors swirling that it might be Daniel Ricciardo's last appearance in Formula One.

The Australian, nicknamed Honey Badger, known for his exuberant

personality and wide grin, has had a tough time since his ill-fated move to McLaren in 2021. Though he won the 2021 Italian GP, he was outclassed by teammate Norris during their two years together. His performance was so poor that McLaren bought out Ricciardo's contract for 2023 and replaced him with fellow Aussie Piastri. Ricciardo rejoined the F1 grid halfway through last year at Red Bull's junior team (then AlphaTauri) and was retained for 2024. The hope was that a good season could open the door for a return to Red Bull Racing, where he had previously secured seven wins.

But having failed to impress this season, Ricciardo is likely to be dropped before the next race in Austin, Texas. The 35-year-old appeared emotional afterward, conceding that Singapore could well have been his last race.

If so, it would mark a tame end to the career of one of F1's most beloved personalities. In his prime, Ricciardo went toe-to-toe with Sebastian Vettel and Verstappen at Red Bull and produced memorable wins.

His iconic "shoey" celebrations — drinking champagne from his race boots — endeared him to fans worldwide, and he played an influential role in popularising the sport globally.

Kush Maini's costly mistake



Meanwhile, India's Kush Maini had a scary crash in Baku during the F2 Feature Race when he stalled on the grid, triggering a multi-car collision. Though he emerged unscathed, his Invicta Racing car was almost destroyed (**above**). More importantly, his reputation took a hit when stewards' reports blamed him for the collision. "The driver of Car 9 failed to engage the Start Set Up Procedure for the start of the race, an error that led to the car stalling on the grid and causing the subsequent collision," read the report from the stewards.

"The Stewards determined that, because of this, Maini was wholly responsible for the collision and, as a result, handed him a 10-second time penalty. Since Maini did not finish the Feature Race, his time penalty was converted into a five-place grid penalty for the next race," the report added.